

The Household Operations Toolkit

The real working documents of the private-service profession, ready to use, ready to carry into your first house.

A confidential resource of Maison Amarine. These are the instruments a professional runs a household with. Learn them here, adapt them to your house, and you will look like someone who has done this for years, from your very first week.

A word before you begin

A great house is not run on memory or charm. It is run on quiet systems that make excellence repeatable and make you, over time, impossible to replace. The tools in this kit are those systems.

Two rules govern all of them. First, **discretion**: every one of these documents contains private information, so it is kept secure, never left open, never photographed, never taken home, and never discussed. Second, **the manual survives you**: you build these so that if you were gone tomorrow, the house would keep running. Paradoxically, that is exactly what makes a household refuse to let you go.

Use each template below as a skeleton. Fill it, tailor it to your principal, and keep it current. A tool that is out of date is worse than no tool at all.

1. The Household Manual

What it is. The single reference that describes how the house runs: its people, its standards, its rhythms, its suppliers, its emergencies. If a new member of staff arrived tomorrow, this is what would make them useful in a day rather than a month.

What it contains.

- **The house.** Addresses, access, alarm and gate procedures, room by room notes, systems (heating, water, pool, generator), and who services each one.
- **The people.** The family and their key contacts; the staff, roles and hours; the reporting lines. Who decides what, and who is merely relayed to.
- **The standards.** How the house is presented when the principal is in, and when guests are expected. Table settings, flowers, linens, temperatures, lighting, scent. The specifics that make a house feel cared for.
- **The rhythms.** The daily, weekly, monthly and seasonal tasks. Deep cleans, window cleaning, garden cycles, wardrobe changeovers, wine deliveries.
- **The emergencies.** A cross-reference to the Emergency Protocol (tool 6).

How to use it. Start it in your first fortnight, quietly, by observing. Do not present it. Build it for the house's resilience and your own value, and update it the day anything changes.

2. The Principal's Book

What it is. The most valuable and most confidential document you will ever keep: the record of your principal's preferences, so that their world is arranged to their taste without their ever having to ask. Old service families simply call it *the book*.

What it records (a preference, never an opinion, and never a judgement):

- **The table.** Foods loved and refused, allergies, how coffee and tea are taken, still water not sparkling, the wines kept and the ones never served, portion sizes, timings.
- **Comfort.** Room temperature, the side of the bed, pillow firmness, the blanket on a flight, the scent of the house, morning light or drawn curtains.
- **Dress and travel.** Preferred airlines and seats, hotels and suites returned to, the car and the route, packing preferences, the toiletries always replaced.
- **People and dates.** Names of family, godchildren, key staff and friends; anniversaries and birthdays; the flowers a spouse loves; the charity that matters.
- **The unspoken.** What is never to be discussed, who is never to be put through, the subjects to steer away from.

How to use it. Build it from a thousand small observations, not from asking. When you notice a preference, record it that evening and act on it the next morning. This single document is the difference between service that reacts and service that anticipates.

3. The Rota (staff schedule)

What it is. The schedule of who is on duty, when, and where, including cover, rotations and time off. A well-kept rota is invisible; a badly kept one is felt by everyone in the house.

What it holds.

- Each person, their role, their contracted hours and their days off.
- The weekly grid: mornings, afternoons, evenings, and any night cover.
- Rotations across residences, and travel schedules that follow the principal.
- Cover for illness and holidays, agreed in advance, never improvised.
- A clear note of who holds keys, codes and responsibilities on any given shift.

How to use it. Publish it in advance so the team can plan their lives; defend the days off you have promised (the martyr who gives up their rest is on the list of failures for a reason); and never build a rota that only works if nobody is ever ill.

A working, editable version of the rota is provided in the companion spreadsheet.

4. The Household Budget & Expense Log

What it is. The financial record of the household: what is spent, on what, and against which budget. Handling it cleanly is the fastest way to become indispensable, and mishandling it the fastest way to leave.

What it tracks.

- The annual and monthly budget by category: staff, provisions, maintenance, vendors, travel, entertaining, discretionary.
- Every expense, dated, categorised, with the receipt kept.
- Petty cash and any float held, reconciled to the pound.
- A monthly summary the principal or the family office can read at a glance, delivered without being asked.

The golden rule. Report before you are asked, and never let the principal discover a number you should have surfaced. Precision here buys you trust everywhere else.

A working, editable budget and expense tracker is provided in the companion spreadsheet.

5. The Travel Brief

What it is. The single document that makes a principal's journey seamless, from the door of one home to the door of the next. You prepare one for every trip.

What it contains.

- **The itinerary.** Every movement with times, in the principal's time zone and local time: cars, aviation, transfers, arrivals.
- **Aviation.** Aircraft, tail number, FBO, crew contact, catering, luggage limits, ground handling.
- **The stay.** Hotel or villa, suite, check-in arrangements, the room readied to preference (tool 2), a local contact on the ground.
- **The book on the move.** Restaurants reserved, appointments, security coordination, the pharmacy and hospital nearest to each location.
- **Contingencies.** The plan if a flight slips, a weather alternative, a spare of everything that matters.

How to use it. Build it days ahead, never discovered on the day. Anticipate jet lag by quietly adjusting the first day's plans and meals. Give the principal a life that simply flows, and let the work be invisible.

6. The Emergency & Security Protocol

What it is. The calm, written answer to the question no one wants to face in the moment. In a crisis you do not think, you follow the protocol, and that is precisely why it exists.

What it covers.

- **Medical.** Each family member's allergies, conditions, medications and blood type; the nearest hospital and a trusted private doctor for every residence; the location of first-aid and any prescribed devices.
- **Security.** The close-protection team and how to reach them; never plan a movement without them; the procedure for an unknown person at the gate or a journalist's approach; safe rooms and evacuation routes.
- **The house.** Fire, flood, power failure and alarm procedures; the shut-off points for water, gas and electricity; the engineers on call.
- **Escalation.** Who is called, in what order, for what kind of event. The one page you could hand to a stranger and have them act correctly.

How to use it. Write it before you need it, keep it current, and make sure the whole team knows where it lives. Rehearse the fire and evacuation steps quietly, once, so they are muscle memory.

7. The Vendor Black Book

What it is. Your private, confidential register of trusted contacts, built one favour at a time over a career: the people who answer, who deliver, who never let you down. It is the quiet reason a principal keeps you, and it is never lent.

What it holds (per contact: name, what they do, why they are trusted, how to reach them, and any account or terms):

- The florist who answers at midnight, the private chef available at short notice, the wine merchant, the tailor and the shoe repair.
- The villa and yacht agents, the charter broker, the fixer in each city the family visits.
- The doctor, the dentist, the vet, the discreet clinic.
- The car service, the private aviation contact, the security firm.
- The restaurants that will find a table, the maitres d' who know your principal by name.

How to use it. Guard it as you would a confidence. Build it deliberately: every excellent supplier you meet goes in, with a note on why. In five years it is worth more than any single skill you own.

8. The Inventory & Asset Register

What it is. The record of what the house holds: the fine and the fragile, the valuable and the insured. It protects the principal, and it protects you.

What it lists.

- Art, antiques, silver, fine china and glass, with provenance where it exists (tool for a future conversation with a collector).
- Wine and spirits, logged by the cellar record.
- Watches, jewellery and other high-value items, with their locations and insured values.
- Vehicles, and any registered assets of the residence.
- Condition notes and photographs, and the date of the last check.

How to use it. Keep it current, reconcile it periodically, and never let a valuable move in or out of the house without a record. When something is lent, insured, restored or sold, the register is updated the same day.

The one page that matters most

If you build only one of these in your first month, build **the Principal's Book**. Everything else runs the house; the book is what makes the principal feel known. And in this profession, to be trusted with a life, and to arrange it so gracefully that the person never has to ask, is the whole of the art.

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